

ECTLC LESSON PLAN

The Communication Lifecycle

Primary framework: **Intent Check** → **Sender** → **Medium** → **Receiver** → **Feedback**

Supporting principle: **Congruency**, what you think, what you say, and what you do should match.

Lesson Snapshot

Audience: ECTLC Men's, Women's, and FRM participants

Length: 30-45 minutes

Format: Interactive teaching, discussion, and short application exercise

Big idea: Communication is not complete when words leave your mouth. It is complete when the message is received accurately and confirmed through feedback.

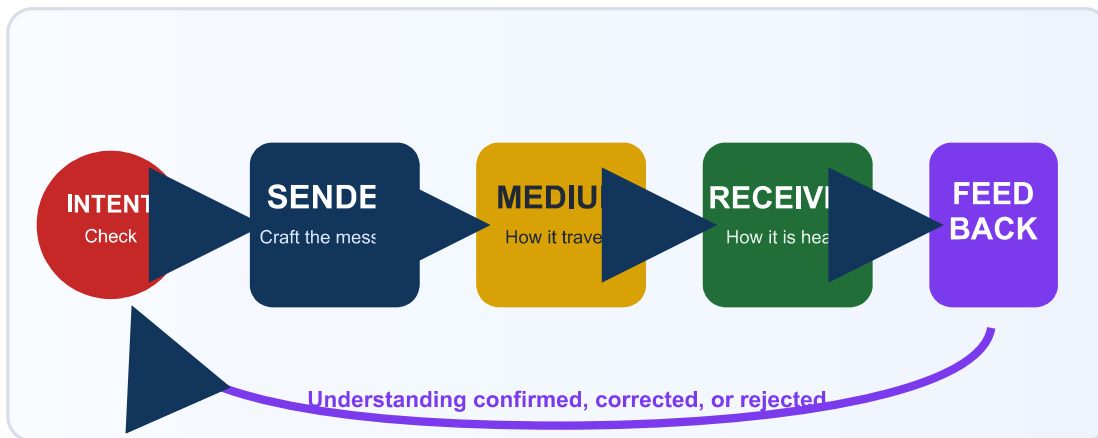
Opening Question

Ask the room: "Have you ever said something and then thought, that is not what I meant?"

Follow up: "Have you ever heard something and reacted strongly, then later realized you misunderstood it?"

A broken message can create real conflict, even when nobody started with bad words.

Centerpiece Graphic - The Communication Lifecycle



Teaching line: **Bad intent poisons everything that follows. Clear intent strengthens every step that follows.**

1 Intent Check

Before the message is crafted, the sender must check intent. Am I trying to help, clarify, correct, control, embarrass, punish, or win? **Bad intent poisons the cycle at the beginning.** Even a technically correct message can feel hostile if the intent is wrong.

2 Sender

The sender builds the message. Effective communication starts with clarity, emotional regulation, timing, and congruency. Ask: What do I mean? What outcome do I want? What tone matches that outcome?

3 Medium

The medium is how the message travels, face to face, phone, text, written note, body language, posture, facial expression, and tone. Important messages usually need a stronger medium. Sensitive correction rarely goes well through weak or rushed channels.

4 Receiver

The receiver does not hear the message in a vacuum. People filter messages through stress, shame, fear, past experiences, assumptions, authority dynamics, and current mood. Effective communicators anticipate that the receiver may hear more than the literal words.

5 Feedback

Feedback completes the cycle. The receiver signals what was actually heard. Feedback can confirm, distort, or repair the message. Strong communicators ask for feedback instead of assuming understanding, for example, “Tell me what you heard me say.”

How Effective Communication Uses Each Part to Craft the Message

Intent Check

- Start with honesty about motive
- Do not use communication as a weapon
- Decide whether the goal is clarity, care, correction, or collaboration

Sender

- Choose clear words
- Match tone to goal
- Stay congruent, what you think, say, and do should match

Medium

- Use the right channel for the weight of the message
- Serious issues usually need direct conversation
- Text is weak for emotional nuance

Receiver

- Assume the listener may carry stress or defensiveness
- Leave room for clarification
- Do not overload with too many points at once

Feedback

- Check for understanding
- Invite restatement
- Repair early if misunderstanding appears

Simple repair lines:

“That did not come out right. Let me say it again.”

“What did you hear me say?”

“What I mean is this...”

“Let’s slow down and make sure we understand each other.”

Congruency

Definition: Being congruent means what you think matches what you say, and what you say matches what you do.

- **Incongruent:** “I’m not mad,” while your tone is sharp and your posture is aggressive.
- **Congruent:** “I am frustrated, and I want to address this calmly.”

Teaching point: Congruency increases trust. Incongruency creates confusion, suspicion, and conflict.

Where Communication Breaks Down Most Often

- **Bad intent at the beginning**, wanting to shame, control, or “win”
- **Sender distortion**, saying the wrong thing for the feeling underneath
- **Poor medium**, trying to handle serious issues through a weak channel
- **Receiver filtering**, hearing the message through fear, stress, or assumption
- **Missing feedback**, assuming understanding instead of confirming it

Assumption replaces communication when feedback is missing.

ECTLC Application Discussion

Ask the room: Where does this matter most in daily life here?

- Roommates
- Campus Advisors
- Staff direction and correction
- Work therapy settings
- Family calls
- Transportation coordination

Key connection: Many conflicts are not caused by the first sentence. They are caused by a damaged lifecycle, wrong intent, weak delivery, poor interpretation, or no feedback loop.